

PROCESS OF HARVESTING AND PREPARING COCOA BEANS



Cutting cacao pods from the tree



Carrying the cacao pods from the farm to a central location



Cracking cacao pods to remove seeds or beans



Drying the cacao seeds or beans



Small flowers grow on the trunk and branches. They are pollinated by tiny flies rather than butterflies or bees

CACAO TREE

Grows in tropical forest between 26 degrees north and 26 degrees south of the equator

FLOWERING

Tree flowers twice a year and not all flowers become a cocoa pod

First flowering: June/July
Second flowering: September/October

HARVESTING

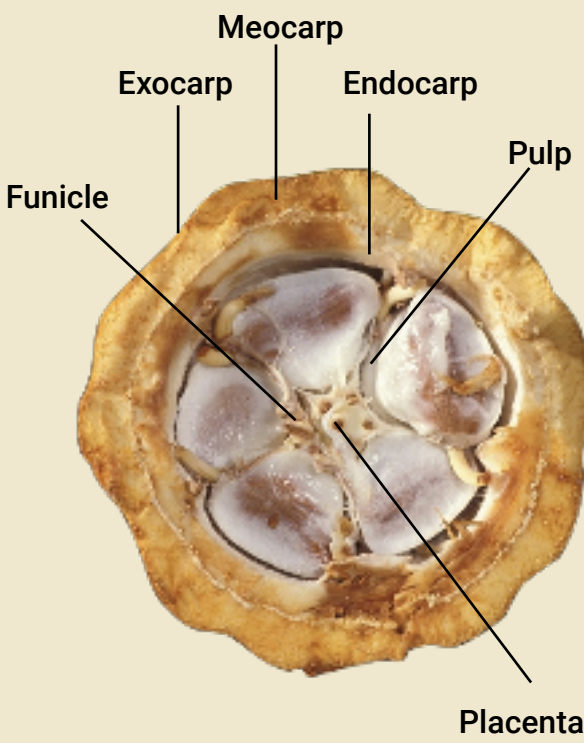
Harvesting of cocoa beans can proceed all year, but the bulk of the crop is gathered in two flush periods occurring from October to February and from May to August. In many countries, cocoa can be harvested at any time of the year.

A single tree may yield up to 70 fruits annually, and the fruits ripen in less than six months.

The cocoa tree can reach 4–20 m (13-66 ft) in height and can live for up to 40 years although the commercial life of a cocoa tree is usually about 25 years.

CACAO

Cacao, (*Theobroma cacao*), also called cocoa, is a tropical evergreen tree in the family Malvaceae. Its seeds, called cocoa beans, are processed into cocoa powder, cocoa butter, and chocolate. The word 'cocoa' comes from the Spanish term 'cacao,' derived from the Nahuatl term 'cacahuati.' Cocoa is a valuable crop that was first cultivated successfully in the equatorial region of South America approximately 5,300 years ago, by the Mayan and the Aztec people.



Every pod has 20-60 seeds or beans

Each bean contains 40-50% fat which is also known as cocoa butter. The butter is used to treat wounds, skin condition, burns, split lip and fatigue

Pods are green when young and yellow when ripe

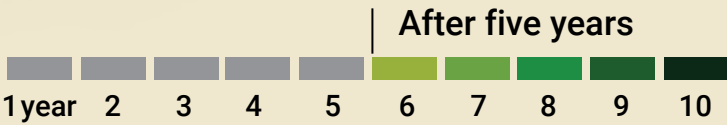
Pod Height 15-30 cm

Pod Width 8-10 cm

The young leaves are used to disinfect wounds



AGE OF MATURITY



COCOA CONSUMPTION WORLDWIDE (2021)

Global consumption volume of cocoa in 2021, by region (in 1,000 metric tons)



TOP 10 CACAO PRODUCING COUNTRIES

In 2020, world production of cocoa beans was 5.8 million tons, led by Ivory Coast with 38% of the total. Secondary producers were Ghana and Indonesia (each with about 14%)



Cote d'Ivoire
2,200,000 tons



Ghana
800,000



Indonesia
739,483



Nigeria
340,163



Ecuador
327,909



Cameroon
290,000



Brazil
269,731



Sierra Leone
193,156



Peru
160,289



Dominican Republic
77,681

COCOA VARIETIES

There are four main varieties of the cacao plant: forastero, criollo, trinitario, and nacional.



FORASTERO

Forastero is primarily cultivated in West Africa and is known as bulk cocoa. Forastero variety still dominates in world chocolate production.



CRIOLLO

Criollo plants make up less than 1 to 5% of the total crop production in the world. Criollo beans are regarded as super fine cocoa, and sought after by craft chocolate makers.



TRINITARIO

Trinitario beans make up less than 10% of the total cocoa production. This hybrid strain spread from the Caribbean islands to South America in the 19th and 20th centuries. It is the least pure.



NACIONAL

The least known cocoa was only recently rediscovered in Peru in 2011. It is regarded as the world's rarest cocoa. Chocolates made with nacional beans are rich, creamy, and with little bitterness.

The Life Cycle of Cacao Tree



bit.ly/3ElgVp

Sources: <https://barandcocoa.com>, ourworld in data
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